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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Packed pews: understanding evangelical group formation

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Abstract

Evangelicals are one of the largest subgroups of the US population. With formal associations over 200 years old, they are certainly not new on the scene. Yet, their political group activity has remained relatively unexplored. Why do they emerge and what constitutes the evangelical group universe? Using an original dataset of evangelical groups and drawing upon a rich literature of theories of group formation, I use population ecology to explain evangelical interest group emergence. I find that evangelical groups are approaching a critical mass where competition for resources discourages group formation. I also find strong evidence that the political polarization of the mid-1990s encouraged group formation at a staggering rate. I also demonstrate that evangelicals are responsive to "threats" to their social values. In addition to this, I control for a number of other variables that further bolster the evidence that population ecology is a good way to explain a complex religious group.

Keywords Interest groups · Evangelicals · Religion · Population ecology · Density dependence

Introduction

In 1860, Reverend Rufus Clark wrote that "in this nineteenth century, and under the light of free and Christian institutions, we should be called upon to discuss anew the subject of the African slave trade" which is diametrically opposed to "the professed aim of our political institutions"(1860, 7). The 102-page paper containing these quotes was published nationally by the American Tract Society—itself established just 35 years earlier (Balmer 2004). The society is one of the oldest extant groups founded in pursuit of evangelical ideals, and this was one of the first pieces of evangelical literature calling for policy change. Evangelical interests did not die in the 1800s. Rather, they have taken fairly direct roles in our political system for years. For example, Focus on the

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Family has for decades maintained an active role in position-taking on salient political issues like abortion (see, e.g., Earll 2014). High-profile examples like this one highlight important, unanswered questions about evangelical organizations: Is there an evangelical interest "universe?" If so, how large is it? What explains the emergence of groups within it? In this paper, I seek to answer these questions with an original dataset and the principles of population ecology.

Evangelicals are a politically powerful constituency in the USA. Defining what and who evangelicals are has been a puzzle for religious (Kidd 2019) and secular (FitzGerald 2017) historians, think tanks and research institutions (Pew 2012), political scientists (Hertzke 1988; Hertzke et al. 2018; McTague and Pearson-Merkowitz 2013; Margolis 2018, 2019; Mathew 2018; Wong 2018), and evangelicals themselves (NAE 2019). There is no doubt, however, that evangelicals are politically powerful, and their level of political involvement and religiosity is unique to the USA (Layman 1997; Malloy 2017; Margolis 2019). Since Key (1942) defined a "pressure group" as an institution separate from Congress, the Presidency, and even the political party, scholars have worked to explain how groups emerge and achieve their goals. Interest groups operate in different ways and exercise considerable influence over policy outcomes. Studying evangelicals offers insight into non-lobbying political groups. With most of the typical data being inaccessible (e.g., funding, membership rosters) and/or nonexistent (e.g., lobbying expenditures), explaining their emergence and propagation is difficult. Nevertheless, they are not immune to previously observed patterns of group formation.

In what follows, using an original dataset, I track the growth in the number of interest groups representing evangelicals in the USA and use population ecology to explain the patterns I uncover. I find that evangelical groups exist in significant numbers and are susceptible to density dependence and that their formation is deeply affected by political change. This finding is consistent with prior investigations into organizational ecology (see, e.g., Fisker 2013; Hannan and Freeman 1977; Lowery and Gray 1995; Nownes 2004) but provides insight into the formation of groups that are certainly political but cannot be analyzed using more conventional measures.

So what implications does the study of religious groups have for interest group scholars? A major finding of this research is that evangelicals do not belong to a single non-party group despite sharing similar ideology. This would suggest that evangelicals, though nearly uniformly Republican, are not acting as one individual group but, rather, as "coalitions of groups" (Bawn et al. 2012, 571). Especially in light of the 2016 presidential election, this research adds new considerations to theories of party asymmetry (Grossmann and Hopkins 2015). On a more practical level, the findings and data presented here establish the existence and macro-level behavior of evangelical interests. Prior research on evangelicals has focused almost exclusively on micro-level behavior.

Interest groups: types, scope, and formation

The most famous indictment of the composition of the interest group universe likely comes from Schattschneider (1960), who noted that groups are primarily concerned with upper class problems (see also, Schlozman 1984). More recently, Strolovitch

(2006) finds that lower-class groups are less likely to see policy advancement by group activity. Some populations, like poor Americans, have trouble finding any interest group representation despite high issue salience (Miler 2018). The status of being lower class or disadvantaged leads to an expected deficit in interest group activity. Conversely, being well-resourced leads to an expected healthy growth of interest group formation and policy success. That success is found in different ways among advantaged groups (Schlozman 1984). Many "traditional" interest groups prioritize inside lobbying, working with friendly legislators and bureaucratic agencies (Hall and Deardorff 2006; Hall and Miler 2008; Leech et al. 2005; McCubbins and Schwartz 1984).

Other groups take on outside lobbying with tactics such as influencing public opinion (Kollman 1998), mobilizing voters (Anzia 2011; Hertel-Fernandez 2017; Rosenstone and Hansen 1993), and disseminating information (Franz et al. 2016). These tactics are prevalent when groups are legally limited in the scope of their political activities (Berry and Wilcox 2007; Walker 1991). Groups like 501(c)(3) nonprofits are not traditional in the sense that they are limited in how much political involvement in which they can partake. Lobbying activity is subject to either a "substantial part" or 501(h) "expenditure" test. Further, 501(c)(3)s "are absolutely prohibited from directly or indirectly participating in, or intervening in, any political campaign on behalf of (or in opposition to) any candidate for elective public office" (Internal Revenue Service 2015). This makes them harder to study but *not* less important. The majority of evangelical groups are 501(c)(3)s lacking formal membership rosters, the backing of big donors, and regulated with heavy restrictions on lobbying. This means a significant number of evangelical groups can be influencing policy in ways not visible to the casual observer (e.g., distribution of literature on politicized topics, endorsements of controversial policy positions, etc.). Being difficult to study, one might assume that these groups are often short-lived or inconsequential, but the groups have incredible longevity with a low dissolution rate—their status as associations (as opposed to formal membership clubs) likely lends to this long-term durability (Anderson et al. 2004).

The most famous work on group formation is *The Logic of Collective Action* where Olson (1965) outlines incentive theory. Later scholars have added additional considerations to the simplified cost-benefit analysis of group formations (see, e.g., Berry 1978; Salisbury 1969; Chong 1991; Hojnacki 1997; Hojnacki et al. 2012; Salisbury 1969; Walker 1983, 1991). While all aspects and assumptions may not hold true in all circumstances, the core of incentive theory—that people must be enticed with some benefit of joining—has been an important way for scholars to explain interest group formation. Other theories have added entirely new considerations. Meyer and Imig (1993), for example, suggest an opportunistic quality to group formation, theories of competition (see, e.g., Nownes 2019) suggest external factors bear greater importance, and Moe (1981) espouses a pluralist view with emphasis on group goals. Regardless of the implications of any of these theories, interest groups can and do form regularly. Modeling all of the possible exogenous factors is difficult as such factors are often not easily quantifiable, inaccessible, or just unknown. Studying group formation with largely inaccessible data is particularly problematic but can be addressed through an ecological approach.

Population ecology models explain formation as a factor of resources (Hannan and Freeman 1977). Similar groups have similar needs for resources for which they must compete (Barron et al. 1994; Chamberlain et al. 2019; Hutchinson 1957; Lowery and Gray 1993). While earlier studies look to the individual to explain group formation (Truman 1951; Walker 1991), population ecology models explain group formation at the macro-level. Gray (1993, 205) sought to develop a theory that applied "to a larger characterization" of the interest group universe. They found that unlimited population growth is not likely even if a potential group overcame hurdles at the micro- (or, individual) level (e.g., Olson's "free-rider" problem) (Lowery and Gray 1995). There is a "carrying capacity of political systems" that prevent infinite growth (Lowery and Gray 1995, 25). An interest group's survival is dependent on its peers' usage of resources. Population ecology models assert density dependence such that the number of interest group formations is correlated with the number of existing groups relative to the available "space." At first, increases in density lead to increased foundings (i.e., growth encourages growth). However, as the carrying capacity of the interest space is reached, this relationship changes direction, and increases in density lead to a decline in group foundings. The relationship of foundings to density can be thought of as an S-shaped curve. The dissolution (or death) of interest groups is explained in a similar, yet inverse way (Nownes and Lipinski 2005). With earlier theories describing the difficulties in motivating individuals to form a group, density dependence remains a compelling way to study interest groups in the aggregate. It also provides an initial way to define the "universe" of a subset of groups.

Evangelicals in political science

Evangelicals have been understudied in political science literature—primarily for measurement reasons (Burge and Lewis 2018). Most surveys of people, groups, and institutions classify religion much more simply making few distinctions between different traditions. It is the norm to see entire denominations grouped because of outdated nominal tradition (e.g., Southern, evangelical Baptists and traditional Baptists are often just listed as "Baptist"). It is also not uncommon to delineate only between Catholics and Protestants. Recently, however, there has been an uptick in the attention given to evangelicals, primarily from behavioral and historical perspectives. For example, several studies explore why (see, e.g., Wilcox 1992; Wilcox and Robinson 2011) and to what extent (see, e.g., Djupe et al. 2018; Margolis 2018, 2019) evangelicals care about politics . There is also some descriptive work in this vein (see, e.g., Pew 2015; OpenSecrets 2019). To say that evangelicals have been invisible in the literature on institutions is not accurate, but they certainly have not enjoyed high visibility. There has been some work on the policy involvement of churches (Fink 2009; Karnes et al. 2007), and Guth (1983) had a bleak prediction on the longevity of groups within the American "Christian Right" in the 1980s. He was wrong. The Christian Right has cemented itself in our political system—recent emphasis on partisan attitudes, for example, has brought up questions of evangelical legislator party

alignment (McTague and Pearson-Merkowitz 2013; Mathew 2018) and is active at the grassroots level (Djupe and Conger 2012).

Evangelical interest group activity has not gone entirely unnoticed. But do interest groups representing evangelicals take an active role on the Hill? They are certainly not wholly absent. Evangelicals feature heavily as one of five main religious groups of interest in a report from Pew (2012) about lobbying expenditures. Other, similar studies have also looked at religious interest groups and their lobbying activity (i.e., how much they spend) (Hertzke 1988; Hertzke et al. 2018). These studies are illustrative but focus on only a few types of organizations; notably those with actively filed lobbying disclosure statements and/or a Washington, D.C. address. The research is largely concerned with questions of money in politics, and the number of evangelical groups with these characteristics is small. Study of traditional interest groups (i.e., those meeting/lobbying/working on the Hill) is important, but it does not encompass all political group activity. It misses out on the hundreds of thousands of newsletters that promote specific public policies, the influence of social values over voting in tight-knit communities, and the malleable public opinion of people who have never come within 150 miles of Gucci Gulch. To date, no literature in political science has looked beyond K Street for a comprehensive analysis of evangelical group population.

Theory

While incentive theory is likely applicable to the manner in which evangelical groups attract members, it is difficult to operationalize due to the broad nature of "incentives." This is especially true for religious organizations where benefits are not always tangible, membership is often not formal, and political advocacy efforts are not superficially apparent. Olson (1965) would argue that there must be some benefit to joining and/or supporting a group. While some groups offer tangible items such as newsletters (e.g., Focus on the Family), these are unlikely to meet the threshold required to overcome a "free-rider" problem. However, consider the benefit that increased social capital (Putnam 2001) can bring to a given community. Communal goals are an excellent way to achieve this social capital, and evangelicals have many shared policy interests (Wong 2018). The list of policy preferences relating to every group is long, so it is not practical to use a singular policy as an explanation for group formation. A macro-level puzzle needs a macro-level solution. So, I turn to density dependence to explain the emergence of evangelical groups. Specifically, in what follows I test this hypothesis:

> H_1: The number of existing groups positively correlates with the number of group formations until a critical mass is reached at which point the relationship inverses.

Incentive theory has a unique view of threats. If individual-level threats are higher than the benefits associated with group membership, people will be less likely to join a group. With evangelicals, there is an important point to be made for how "threats" are perceived, though. Threats faced by evangelicals are, by-and-large, not

threats to individuals. Rather, they are threats to social values and norms, archetypal collective goods. Evangelicals do not have a history of personal persecution in the USA, nor have they been subjected to less freedoms than other demographic groups. Their status as primarily white, conservative people has insulated them from individual threat.[1] The idea that competition for policy change/consistency is also pluralistic (see, e.g., Denzau and Munger 1986) should be considered—i.e., acknowledging that politics affects religion and vice versa (Djupe et al. 2018). What happens when evangelical values are threatened? I explore this question by testing this, my second hypothesis:

> H_2: Salient shocks (or threats) to evangelical social values will positively correlate with increases in group formation in response.

Political scientists have given the Republican Revolution of 1994 considerable attention in evaluating its implications for American politics. As a result, a massive literature on increasing partisanship has emerged (see, e.g., Koger and Lebo 2017; Lee 2009; Mason 2018; Mayhew 2005). We also know that evangelicals are highly partisan (see, e.g., Margolis 2018; Wong 2018). If evangelicals are particularly responsive to party politics, we would expect that increased polarization would highlight a need for greater representation. So, as evangelicals become increasingly politically polarized, it is reasonable to assume that that partisanship plays a key role in evangelical group formation. Since evangelicals are closely aligned with Republicans, increasing Republican representation in Congress likely correlates with group formation. This yields my final hypothesis:

> H_3: Evangelical group formation is responsive to political polarization such that the intensive party politics of the mid-1990s correlates with increased group formation.

Data

Typical sources of interest group date are inadequate to study evangelical organizations. These groups are not churches, but they are often "parachurch" organizations. Some of them are overtly political, but most do not donate politically or hire lobbyists. They also do not typically have formal membership structures. Instead, they rely on donations, and "members" are those donors plus whomever they disburse information to (via e-mail, posted newsletters, etc.). So what emerges are groups that (1) exist outside of a church and (2) focus their efforts toward policy change via constituent education.

Identifying evangelical associations was challenging for several reasons. Most importantly, there is no solid definition of what an evangelical is. If I were studying

[1] Around 17% of self-identified evangelicals are Black or Latino (Pew 2014). None of the organizations I identify were primarily focused on minority membership. I recognize that this could influence the findings in my results section. However, these ethnic groups tend to behave differently than Whites (see, e.g., Wong 2018), so if there was an impact, it would make my findings conservative estimates.

traditional lobbying groups, I would be able to aggregate data from lobbying reports as Lowery and Gray (1995) do. Nownes and Lipinski (2005) use a mix of archival data and secondary sources such as the *Encyclopedia of Associations* to build a group population list. Both of these approaches rely on a few assumptions. In the former case, groups were only counted by Lowery and Gray if they had an active D.C. lobbying presence. The latter relies on some level of self-reporting and sufficient distinction to warrant a specific encyclopedic classification. These assumptions are problematic for my research. There are few evangelical interest groups involved in active D.C. lobbying, and most of these groups are relatively new (Hertzke et al. 2018). For most of history, political scientists (and academia generally) have failed to recognize evangelicals as a distinct group of Christians. For example, most historic work distinguishes only between Protestants and Catholics. Other works classify things more strangely. For example, the *Encyclopedia of Associations* lists Focus on the Family (a preeminent evangelical group) as a "family" association instead of an evangelical, Protestant, or even Christian one. For reasons like this, though it is widely considered comprehensive, the *Encyclopedia of Associations* would not be practically useful, as a researcher would have to analyze over 100 volumes each with about 10,000 entries. Further, as Berry (1999, 2007) point out, the nonprofit status of many evangelical groups precludes them from being identifiable in political ways.

Here, I rely primarily on two sources for identification of evangelical groups. First, I use the most comprehensive resource on evangelical study with over 3000 reference entries, the *Encyclopedia of Evangelicalism* (Balmer 2004). Second, as a robustness check I use *Evangelical America: An Encyclopedia of Contemporary American Religious Culture* (Demy and Shockley 2017) which focuses on evangelical cultural shifts in the 21st century. For the purposes of this research, I included groups that engaged in outreach, policy education, and/or direct political activity at the state, local, and/or federal levels. For most groups, whether or not they fit this definition was apparent in their encyclopedic entries. Consider the American Colonization Society, whose entry states it "sought to 'repatriate' blacks to Africa... [with] support from a broad, sometimes contradictory coalition of politicians and evangelicals" (Balmer 2004, 17). However, if there was any question as to the nature of the group, I defaulted to published mission statements. I did not include organizations whose primary purpose was either gathering for religious worship or internal education. Single churches were excluded, but I did include "parachurch" organizations (e.g., the First Baptist Church of Springfield would be excluded but the Southern Baptist Convention is included).[2] The founding and (when applicable) dissolution dates of groups were listed in the encyclopedias. I cross-checked that data with the official websites of the organizations. If there were any discrepancies, I defaulted to the organization's stated establishment date. For groups that are now defunct or lack an official website, I searched for news articles about the group on Nexis Uni. If

[2] It should be noted that several churches/colleges/universities founded or were founded as a result of other evangelical groups. For example, Liberty University shares its founder, Jerry Falwell Sr., with the Moral Majority.

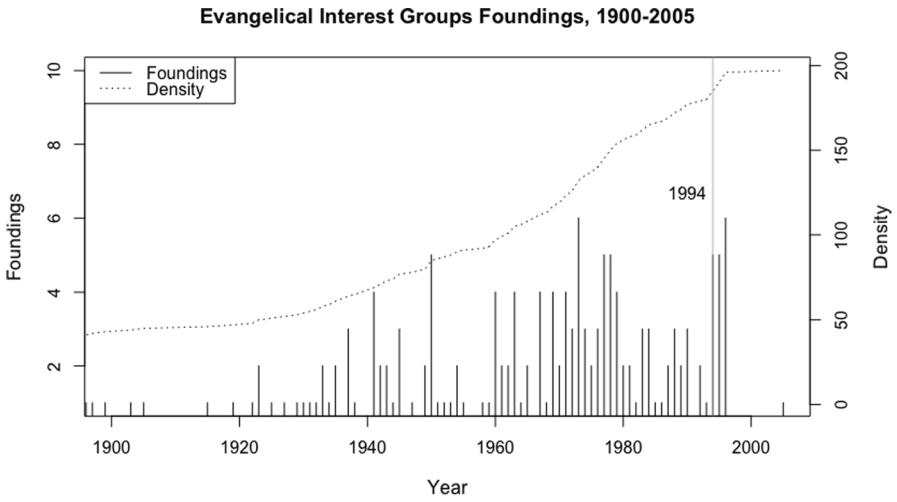

Fig. 1 Density Graph

I did not find conflicting information, I used the founding dates in the encyclopedias. If there was no official website and no news articles mentioning the name of the organization available, I excluded it from the data.[3]

I first collected the name of the group, founding/dissolution date, and other relevant information in August 2019. Then, I aggregated the number of foundings by year and created a cumulative sum that accounted for both foundings and dissolutions. This cumulative sum represents the density of the evangelical interest group universe in a given year. The first known evangelical association I include here, the American Board of Commissioners for Foreign Missions, was founded in 1810. The last groups included were founded in 2005, resulting in an original dataset spanning 196 years with 197 discrete organizations. I was then able to create numerous dummy variables for period effects and join these with existing data on evangelical population and party-control variables.

Figure 1 is a graphical representation of the foundings and density of evangelical groups. The vertical bars represent the number of organizations founded in a given year as denoted by the left- bound y-axis scale. The dotted line represents the growing density (cumulative total) of organizations as denoted by the right-bound y-axis scale. Note that while these two measures are on different scales, this figure provides a good visual of how increases in foundings relates to density. There is steady growth throughout the time period displayed. However, 1994 in particular is associated with a steep growth in the density of organizations. This is important because it supports H_3. H_1 also gains support, albeit somewhat less clearly. Nevertheless, as density is increasing, we do observe more foundings throughout the entirety of the

[3] This happened in only one instance where I could not verify a group's existence by any reasonable means.

data. These descriptive data suggest that the universe of evangelical groups has not yet reached a critical mass where resources are thinned, and groups begin to dissolve at high rates than emerge.

Testing

Because this is count data, I deploy a negative binomial regression[4] to test my hypotheses quantitatively specifying "foundings" as the dependent variable such that they are a function of the independent variables—primarily, *Density*, *Density Sq.*, year-to-year *Republican House Seat Gain*, a dummy for the period of *1980-2005*, and an *External threat* dummy. *Density* and *Density Sq.* test similar, yet uniquely important aspects of H_1. *Density* is fairly straightforward in testing the interaction between the number of existing groups and the number of foundings in a given year. The larger the coefficient is, the longer it will take for density to inversely affect the function. In other words, a larger coefficient indicates a higher "critical mass" before density switches from encouraging to discouraging group formation. *Density Sq.* defines how quickly the function will change from a positive to negative relationship.

I include *External Threat* to test H_2. In the dataset, this is a dummy variable that corresponds to each year in which the Supreme Court made a decision that was salient yet incongruent with evangelical policy preference. Years with a decision are coded as 1, all others are 0. The cases included concerned school prayer/Bibles, abortion, defamation of religious leaders, and other policy areas. A description of the cases and how I selected them can be found in "Appendix."

It is important to consider period effects when discussing group formation of any kind. Because evangelicals are consistently Republican, periods of time associated with intense political realignment and polarization should spur formation. A Republican takeover of the national government, for instance, would create an opportunity for increased input on public policy. Taking advantage of this opportunity, it would be an excellent time for interest groups to emerge (Meyer and Imig 1993). While the 1994 election is in and of itself significant when included as a variable in the tests, I used the number of Republican seats gained each election to ensure the robustness of the results. The substantive significance of intense party politics and radical changes in government control would be captured by that variable. To control for widespread public opinion shifts, I use the public policy mood measure created by Stimson (2018). Specifically, this is a left-right ideological measure of Americans" policy preferences. This aids in determining if evangelical group formation is

[4] Results are substantively identical when using alternative tests like a Poisson or zero-inflated negative binomial regression. To check for serial autocorrelation, I also conducted a linear Poisson autoregressive (par(P)) analysis on the data. Because the density and density squared figures are perfectly correlated, one had to be dropped for that model to converge, so it is not presented in the body of the paper. Nevertheless, the significance of the key independent variables remained unchanged. The par(P) analysis was conducted in R statistical software and was developed by Brandt and Williams (2001).

Table 1 Summary statistics

Statistic	N	Mean	SD	Min	Pctl(25)	Pctl(75)	Max
Foundings	54	2.056	1.731	0	1	3	6
Density	54	145.315	38.706	87	108	178.5	197
Density sq.	54	22,586.830	11,157.780	7569	11,664	31,863	38,809
Public mood	54	60.059	4.508	49.876	57.135	63.948	68.917
Rep. House seat gain	54	1.685	24.281	− 48	− 7	14	54
Evangelical percent	25	0.250	0.028	0.182	0.233	0.274	0.305
External threat	54	0.111	0.317	0	0	0	1

"reactionary" to public behavior or more steadfast and is included in the models as *Public Mood*.

Finally, I use religious population estimates derived from the GSS to account for the number of American evangelicals. These estimates are a popular recoded religious tradition measure known as "RELTRAD" (Burge and Lewis 2018). By recoding respondents' answers to the survey, this religious tradition measure is able to sort people into 1 of 7 religious groupings. It is the most widely accepted measure of the number of evangelicals in the political community (Burge and Lewis 2018; Stetzer and Burge 2015). *Evangelical Percent* is included in the last of my models to test the relationship between the number of evangelicals in the population and likelihood of group formation. Summary statistics for the variables can be seen in Table 1.

Results

The results from my initial tests are in Table 2. I subset the data here to include the years from 1952–2005 (as opposed to the full dataset ranging from 1810 to 2005) for a few practical reasons. First, this period is conceptually more relevant to understanding evangelical group formations and the American political system because we have a clear understanding of the party system during this period (see, e.g., APSA 1950). Second, from a practical perspective, other data like the GSS data I use and the public mood measure are available for the entire time period. To account for intensive party politics that scholars point to as emerging in the 1980s (Lee 2009), I include a dummy variable for the period from 1980 to 2005.

Starting with model 1, Table 2, I find strong support for H_1. The coefficient on *Density* is positive indicating that an increase in density is initially associated with a greater likelihood of group formation. The coefficient on *Density Sq.* is negative, indicating that the relationship between density and formation reverses at some point. The effect here is modest, but it does suggest that the universe had not yet reached capacity in the existing data. The estimated inflection point (where the level of density discourages group formation) would be a density of approximately 204 organizations. The relationship between the cumulative number of groups and

Table 2 Evangelical group formation

	Dependent variable:		
	Foundings, 1952–2005		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Density	0.115***	0.111***	0.105***
	(0.029)	(0.031)	(0.031)
Density sq.	− 0.0004***	− 0.0004***	− 0.0003***
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)
Public mood		0.001	−0.012
		(0.024)	(0.026)
Rep. House seat gain		0.009**	0.008*
		(0.004)	(0.004)
1980-2005		− 0.749**	− 0.722*
		(0.381)	(0.382)
External threat			0.394
			(0.287)
Observations	54	54	54
Log likelihood	− 93.763	− 90.071	− 89.189
Akaike inf. crit.	193.526	192.142	192.378

*$p < 0.1$; **$p < 0.05$; ***$p < 0.01$

Negative binomial regression

Standard errors in parentheses

predicted foundings can be seen in Fig. 2. Note that this figure displays the slowing of foundings as density increases and not the switch to discouragement. The predicted value is plotted as a line with 99% confidence intervals.

Model 2 offers strong support for H_3. Specifically, it shows that evangelical group formation is subject to period political effects. Scholars often look to 1994 as a year of significant political change and partisan polarization in conjunction with the Republican takeover of the House of Representatives. While the modern period (1980–2005) has a strong negative effect on the predicting foundings of evangelical groups, the Republican seat change in the House remains significant. It may appear to be a small effect, but substantively, large Republican party gains have a significant positive effect on the number of organizations emerging. Figure 3 displays the predicted values relative to Republican seat gains in the US House holding *1980–2005* constant at 1 with 90% confidence intervals. Any positive seat change yields an expected predicted founding of at least one organization. When the seat gains surpass 40, the predicted foundings fall comfortably within the 2–4 range. This is consistent with H_3; the 1994 election saw massive gains (54 House seats) for Republicans which positively significantly correlates with the increase in foundings shown in Fig. 1.

H_2 does not gain any statistical support from model 3 in Table 2. Evangelicals may well be spurred by salient threats to their ideology, but more research would need to be done on what exactly those threats are and how they are perceived from

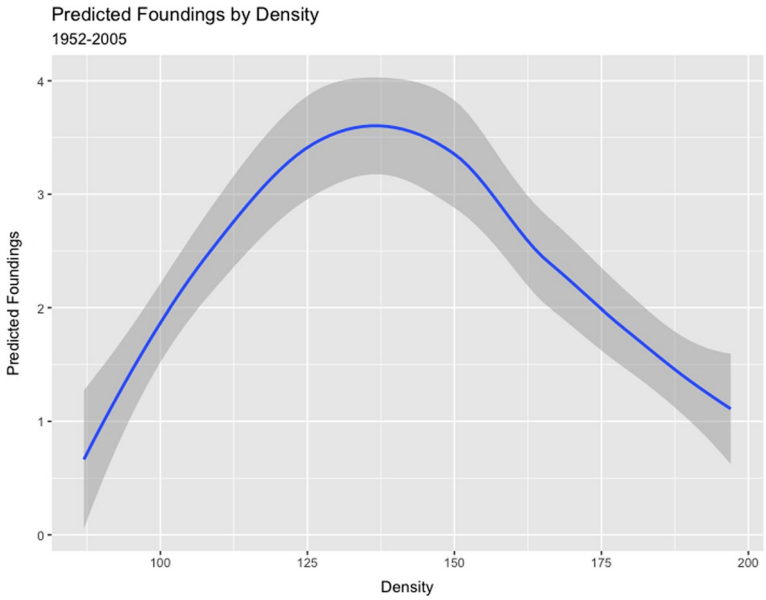

Fig. 2 Predicted Values Graph

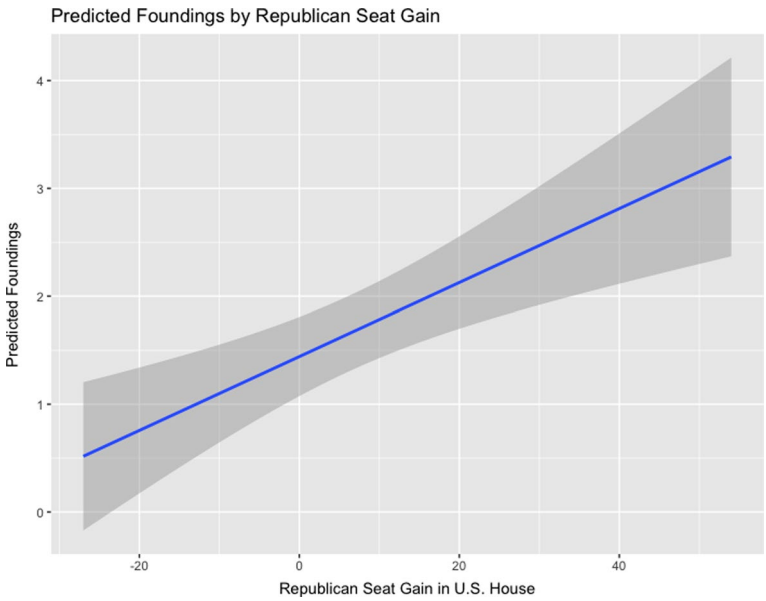

Fig. 3 Predicted Values Graph

a behavioral perspective. Adding additional considerations around Supreme Court cases would introduce a great deal of measurement error to the model, but the substantive effect of the other variables hold regardless.

A common critique of count models in general is that there is an underlying assumption that all groups are equal in impact. This is almost certainly not true, but operationalizing a measure of importance is difficult. For example, does revenue or number of members matter more? What about media salience? Solving this issue is beyond the scope of this paper, but I recognize that the importance of the "Moral Majority" is assumed to be the same as the "American Tract Society."[5] If there were additional endogenous factors (like other groups' income) discouraging group formation, it would not weaken my results. Therefore, the estimates modeled here are likely conservative.

Another variable that worth considering is the number of evangelicals in the country. While there have been significant measurement issues regarding population estimates, most scholars agree that about 25% of Americans identify as an evangelical. Perhaps the most popular measure comes from the recoding of variables in the General Social Survey to create a new measure of religious tradition called "RELTRAD." While the data are noisy, it remains the best estimate of evangelical population for political scientists (Stetzer and Burge 2015). Population ecology would suggest that as a population grows, we would expect more group formation as a factor of increased resources. Similarly, a steady population should have little to no effect on group formation. To account for this here, I used the religious tradition measure to test the effect of *Percent evangelical* in my data for the years it was available. There were 25 years of estimates available, covering the period 1972–2005.

A negative binomial model would not converge with the small number of observations available, so my analysis uses a Poisson regression. I also needed to expand the 25 years of available estimates to run a more complete test, so I performed multivariate imputation by chained equations (with a classification and regression trees method) to fill in the 9 missing years of evangelical population data.[6] Table 3 shows the results using this method. They are largely what would be expected—the size of the evangelical population does not statistically affect group formation. This is not to say that evangelical population is inconsequential, the data simply are not available, nor are they sufficiently varied to allow for any substantive effect. If the percent of evangelicals changed by, for example, 10% in one year, it is possible that this would affect group formation. However, much more research is needed to understand the

[5] In an effort to capture a generalized, monetized measure of group influence, I checked group websites for financial disclosures, secondary sources that report on nonprofit spending, and filed five FOIA requests with the IRS. The first two methods revealed extremely limited information for a few of the groups in the data. The FOIA requests were successful but only allowed for a few years of information to be gathered. Further, the flow of finances varied greatly between the sources that I found. Analyses based on these data were (1) too small to be statistically sound and (2) would likely be heavily biased toward visible groups backed by big donors.

[6] Generally, I find data imputation to be risky given that the model is now fitted to speculative instead of observed data. However, there were too few years of data available to do anything more than a simple regression with the included variables.

Table 3 Evangelical group formation

	Dependent variable Foundings, 1972–2005
Density	− 0.094
	(0.123)
Density sq.	0.0002
	(0.0004)
Public mood	− 0.048
	(0.039)
Rep. House seat gain	0.010*
	(0.006)
Evangelical percent	8.866
	(6.918)
Observations	34
Log likelihood	− 57.638
Akaike inf. crit.	127.277

*$p < 0.1$; **$p < 0.05$; ***$p < 0.01$

Poisson regression

Standard errors in parentheses

total population of evangelicals. These results do not conclusively confirm or reject the possibility of a relationship that population ecology would predict, but they do show that the number of evangelicals in the population is not the most important factor here and now.

Discussion and conclusion

Evangelicals remain an important population for study. Yet, little is known about evangelicals' organizations beyond histories of churches. The evangelical interest group universe is healthy with a growing population (i.e., a very low dissolution rate as shown in Fig. 1) and varying degrees of political involvement. I find strong support for a density dependence model of group formation. The size and direction of the coefficients in my quantitative analyses indicate that there is still room for growth, albeit not much, in the number of evangelical associations. As the *Density Sq.* variable indicated, the number of formations is approaching a point where the slope switches from positive to negative, but it is doing so very slowly. I also found that evangelical group formation was particularly responsive to the political realignment and polarization of the mid-1990s. This suggests that future surges in party polarization may be important in understanding the trajectory of this population. On a more practical note, this research has shed light on the size and scope of the evangelical interest community—a politically important but largely non-traditional collection of interest groups. These findings add to the robustness of population

ecology models in explaining group emergence when there is a lack of conventional measures. This also suggests that at least some segments of the Republican party are driven by coalitions of interest groups (see, e.g., Bawn et al. 2012).

This research has shed light on important aspects on the makeup of the evangelical group universe and the groups formed within it. But, a number of questions remain. Among the most important are those concerned with identifying new ways of measuring group competition. It is easy, for instance, to compare spending patterns of groups with publicly filed lobbying disclosures, but there is no uniform way to quantify competition across groups that are not filing something publicly accessible. Numerous scholars have noted the inherent flaw in the assumption that all groups are assumed equal in count models, but there is no widely accepted alternative. Within the study of population ecology, scholars should look to develop more ways of thinking about competition generally—both intraspecific (e.g., one evangelical group to another) (see, e.g., Nownes and Bell 2018) and interspecific (e.g., an evangelical group to a Catholic group). The pews are packed, and density dependence explains a great deal about how they got that way, but there is still more research to be done to fully understand evangelical interests and non-traditional groups.

Appendix

See Fig. 4, Table 4.

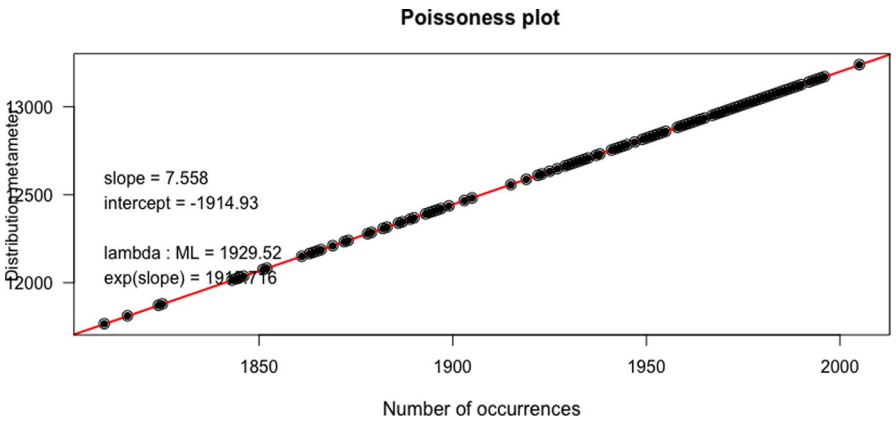

Fig. 4 The count data fit well along a Poisson distribution

Table 4 Evangelical interest group formation

	Dependent variable				
	Foundings 1952–2005				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Density	0.114***	0.093***	0.136***	0.118***	0.122***
	(0.028)	(0.030)	(0.041)	(0.036)	(0.029)
Density sq.	− 0.0004***	− 0.0003***	− 0.0005***	− 0.0004***	− 0.0004***
	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)	(0.0001)
Republican senate control	−0.867***				
	(0.325)				
Republican senate percent		−4.647**			
		(1.842)			
Republican House control			0.330		
			(0.466)		
Republican House percent				0.301	
				(2.241)	
Republican president					−0.353*
					(0.193)
Observations	54	54	54	54	54
Log likelihood	− 88.704	− 89.490	− 92.622	−9 2.862	− 91.217
Akaike inf. crit.	185.409	186.980	193.244	193.723	190.435

Source: Author's data

Poisson regression estimates with standard errors in parentheses

$^{*}p < 0.1$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{***}p < 0.01$

External threats

This is the list of Supreme Court Cases that made up my "external threat" dummy variable. Years that are associated with one of the following decisions were coded as 1; all others were 0. Because I was dealing with roughly six decades of data to analyze (≈60 observations), I did not want to include more than 10% of the cases being coded with the variable to prevent estimation bias. So, I chose to include six cases that were directly applicable to evangelical culture. They were:

- *Engel v. Vitale* (1962)
- *Abington v. Schempp* (1963)
- *Roe v. Wade* (1973)
- *Hustler Magazine v. Falwell* (1988)
- *Lee v. Weisman* (1992)
- *Santa Fe Independent School District v. Doe* (2000)

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Declarations

Conflicts of interest On behalf of the author(s), the corresponding author states that there is no conflict of interest.

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